

GS2 Strategy Guide Governance, Constitution, Polity, Social Justice & International Relations

UPSC Mains General Studies Paper 2

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1. Understanding GS2 Paper Structure

GS2 covers Indian Constitution & Polity, Governance, Social Justice, and International Relations. The paper rewards candidates who demonstrate constitutional awareness, administrative understanding, and a balanced perspective on national and international issues.

Paper Pattern (2025 Latest)

Section	Topics	Approx. Weightage
Constitution & Polity	Historical underpinnings, features, amendments, federalism, judiciary, executive, legislature	80-90 marks
Governance	Accountability, e-governance, citizen charters, RTI, pressure groups, policies	50-60 marks
Social Justice	Education, health, poverty, welfare schemes, rights issues, vulnerable sections	50-60 marks
International Relations	Foreign policy, bilateral/regional groupings, global institutions, India's neighborhood	60-70 marks

Key Insight: GS2 is dynamic — nearly 50% of the paper is directly linked to current affairs. Static portions (constitutional articles, committee recommendations) form the foundation, but contemporary application is what differentiates top scorers.

2. Constitution & Polity: Key Frameworks

2.1 Essential Features of Indian Constitution

- **Basic Structure Doctrine:** Kesavananda Bharati (1973) — Parliament cannot amend the basic structure. Elements: supremacy of Constitution, rule of law, separation of powers, judicial review, federalism, secularism, sovereign democratic republic, liberty and dignity.
- **Federalism:** India is "quasi-federal" (K.C. Wheare) — unitary bias (single Constitution, single citizenship, Parliament's power to reorganize states). Recent trends: cooperative federalism (GST Council, NITI Aayog), competitive federalism (Ease of Doing Business rankings), fiscal federalism issues (tax devolution, cesses).
- **Separation of Powers:** Not strict — overlaps exist (judicial review of legislation, President's ordinance power). Checks and balances through judicial review, impeachment, and no-confidence motions.

2.2 Parliament & State Legislatures

Parliamentary Committees

Financial Committees: Public Accounts (CAG reports), Estimates, Committee on Public Undertakings. Department-related Standing Committees (24 — scrutinize bills, policy). Select Committees (ad hoc for specific bills).

Exam Trend: Recent years show increased questions on Parliamentary committees — their role in legislative scrutiny and executive oversight. The Monsoon Session 2023 had record bill passage without committee scrutiny — this is a hot topic.

Legislative Process & Recent Reforms

- Money vs. Ordinary vs. Constitutional Amendment Bills
- Joint sitting of Parliament: Only 3 instances (Dowry Prohibition, Banking Service Commission, POTA)

- Anti-defection law (10th Schedule): Kihoto Hollohan case — Speaker's decision subject to judicial review
- Office of Profit: Definitions and exemptions, need for comprehensive law

2.3 Judiciary

Aspect	Key Points
Supreme Court	Original, Appellate, Advisory jurisdiction. Article 141 — law declared binding on all courts. Article 144 — civil/ judicial authorities to act in aid of SC
High Courts	Article 226 — writ jurisdiction wider than SC. Supervisory jurisdiction over subordinate courts
Judicial Review	Part of basic structure. Can review legislation (constitutional amendment, ordinary law) and executive action
Judicial Activism	PIL (since 1980s), suo motu cognizance, continuing mandamus. Critique: judicial overreach, separation of powers concerns
NJAC vs Collegium	NJAC struck down (2015) — primacy of judiciary in appointments. Memorandum of Procedure (MoP) still pending finalization.
Case Pendency	4.7 crore+ pending cases (SC 80,000+, HCs 60 lakh+, subordinate 4+ crore). Causes: vacancies (30-40% HC vacancies), adjournment culture, inadequate infrastructure. Solutions: Alternative Dispute Resolution, e-courts, Case management

2.4 Federal Issues & Recent Debates

- **Governor's Role:** Article 356 misuse (B.R. Ambedkar called it "dead letter of the Constitution"). Supreme Court guidelines (S.R. Bommai case) — floor test before dismissal. Recent controversies: Maharashtra (2019), Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu.
- **President's Rule:** Imposed ~135 times. S.R. Bommai (1994): limited judicial review, floor test mandatory, material required. Recent: Maharashtra (2019 — 12 hours), Karnataka (2007), Arunachal (2015).
- **Inter-State Water Disputes:** Article 262 — Parliament can provide for adjudication. Tribunals: Cauvery, Krishna, Godavari, Mahanadi. Issues: delays, no time-bound resolution, implementation challenges. Inter-State River Water Disputes (Amendment) Bill — single tribunal, time limits.

3. Governance & Administration

3.1 Good Governance Principles

Key elements: Participation, Rule of law, Transparency, Responsiveness, Consensus orientation, Equity, Effectiveness, Accountability.

Transparency & Accountability Mechanisms

- **RTI Act (2005):** Landmark — empowers citizens to access information. Issues: exemptions (security, intelligence agencies), pendency (3 lakh+ appeals), attacks on RTI activists, digital RTI implementation challenges.
- **Citizen Charters:** Introduced 1997 (Bureau of Indian Standards). Issues: non-binding, lack of awareness, no penalty for non-compliance. Sevottam model (2006) — 3 components: citizen charter, grievance redress, service delivery.
- **Social Audit:** Mandatory under MGNREGA (Schedule 1). Lokayukta/Lokpal — delayed implementation (Lokpal 2014 after 2011 Jan Lokpal movement).

3.2 E-Governance & Digital Initiatives

Initiative	Purpose	Impact
DigiLocker	Digital document storage	15Cr+ users, Aadhaar-linked, cloud-based
UMANG	Unified mobile app for government services	1200+ services, 68 departments
e-SamikSha	Real-time project monitoring	CPSEs, Central projects tracking
Government e-Marketplace (GeM)	Public procurement portal	15Lakh+ sellers, 1.5 lakh Cr GMV
JAM Trinity	Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile	Direct benefit transfer (DBT): 6.5 Lakh Cr transfers, saved 2.7 Lakh Cr in leakages

3.3 Pressure Groups & Civil Society

Types: Associational (CII, FICCI), Non-associational (caste groups), Institutional (civil services associations), Anomic (spontaneous protests). Role in democracy: articulation of interests, policy influence, accountability. Concerns: elite capture, opaque funding, conflict of interest (revolving door between regulators and industry).

3.4 Welfare Schemes & Service Delivery

- **MGNREGA:** Demand-driven, 100 days employment, legal guarantee. Issues: delayed wages (avg 25 days), low asset quality, fund diversion.
- **PM-KISAN:** 6000/yr income support. Issues: exclusion errors, small farmer definition, does not cover tenants.
- **Ayushman Bharat:** PM-JAY (5 lakh insurance) + HWCs (1.5 lakh health centres). Coverage: 10.74 Cr families, 50,000+ empaneled hospitals.
- **POSHAN Abhiyan:** Targets stunting, undernutrition, anemia (Lakshya 2022 targets, Navchetna approach).

4. Social Justice

4.1 Education

Right to Education (2009)

Article 21A — free and compulsory education for 6-14 years. Issues: quality (ASER 2023 — only 25.6% of Class 3 can read Class 2 text), teacher shortage (10 lakh+ vacancies), 25% EWS reservation in private schools — implementation gaps, infrastructure deficit.

Higher Education Reforms

NEP 2020: Key reforms: 5+3+3+4 structure, multidisciplinary, multiple entry/exit, academic bank of credit, National Research Foundation (NRF). Challenges: Implementation in states vs centre, regulatory overhaul (single regulator HECI), language policy debate (three-language formula), private sector regulation.

4.2 Health

Indicator	India Status	Global Rank/Comparison
Life Expectancy	70.8 years (2023)	Below global average (73.3)
Maternal Mortality Ratio	97/100,000 (2018-20)	SDG target: 70 by 2030
Infant Mortality Rate	28/1000 live births (2020)	Global: 27 (better than India)
Public Health Expenditure	2.1% of GDP (2023-24)	Global avg: 6%, Target: 2.5% by 2025
Out-of-Pocket Expenditure	48.8% of health spending	Drives 55M into poverty annually

4.3 Vulnerable Sections

SC/ST/OBC/EBC Issues

- **Caste Census:** 1931 last comprehensive. 2023: Bihar caste survey renewed debate. Arguments for: evidence-based policy, understanding inter-caste inequality. Arguments against: social division, administrative complexity.
- **Creamy Layer:** Currently only for OBCs. Debate on extending to SC/ST — Indra Sawhney principle, current Supreme Court constitution bench hearing.
- **Manual Scavenging:** Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers Act (2013). Still 60,000+ reported, many more unreported. Issues: enforcement, alternative livelihood, social stigma.

Women & Children

Key Issues: Sex ratio at birth (improving — 929 in 2019-21 vs 918 in 2012-14), child marriage (23.3% of girls married before 18 — NFHS-5), GBV (27% of women experienced physical/sexual violence), declining female labor force participation (32.5% — PLFS 2022-23, rising from 23% in 2017-18 but still low).

Persons with Disabilities

RPwD Act 2016: expanded disability types (7 → 21), 4% reservation in govt jobs, 5% in higher education. Implementation gaps: accessibility in public buildings (only 10% compliant), awareness, data deficit (76% of PwDs live in rural areas with limited services).

5. International Relations

5.1 India's Foreign Policy: Core Principles

Guiding doctrines: Panchsheel (1954), Non-Alignment (Cold War context), Gujral Doctrine (unilateral goodwill to neighbors, 1996-98), Look East → Act East (2014 onwards), Neighbourhood First (2014-), SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region — Indian Ocean).

5.2 India & Major Powers

Country	Key Relationship Features	Challenges
USA	Strategic partnership (2+2 dialogue), iCET (critical tech), QUAD, defense cooperation (C-17, MH-60), civil nuclear deal, H-1B visas	Trade tariffs, Russia ties (S-400), human rights concerns, CAATSA, technology transfer restrictions
China	Trade (\$118B, large deficit of \$83B), border disputes (1962, Doklam 2017, Galwan 2020), BRICS, SCO, RIC (Russia-India-China)	Border incursions, Belt & Road debt trap, military build-up in Tibet, strategic competition in Indian Ocean, no trust post-Galwan
Russia	Traditional ally — defense supplies (60% of Indian military equipment originally Soviet/Russian), S-400 despite CAATSA, energy cooperation, Arctic, NSG support	Weakening defense ties (diversification to US/Israel), delayed deliveries, Ukraine war pressure, declining trade (\$12B)
European Union	Strategic partner (2004), FTA negotiations (resumed 2022), climate cooperation, digital partnerships	Carbon border tax (CBAM), data protection adequacy, FTA stuck on market access/goods

5.3 India's Neighborhood

BIMSTEC vs SAARC

India pivoting toward BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative — 7 members: India, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Thailand, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan) as SAARC is paralyzed by Pakistan. BIMSTEC focuses on security, connectivity, trade — fewer political roadblocks.

Connectivity Projects

- **India-Myanmar-Thailand (IMT) Trilateral Highway:** 1360 km linking Moreh (Manipur) to Mae Sot (Thailand). Delayed due to Myanmar conflict.
- **Chabahar Port (Iran):** Strategic access to Afghanistan/Central Asia bypassing Pakistan. US sanctions risk.
- **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC):** 7200 km (Saint Petersburg-Mumbai), reduces time by 40% vs Suez route.
- **BBIN (Bangladesh-Bhutan-India-Nepal):** Motor vehicles agreement, energy cooperation, subregional connectivity.

5.4 Multilateral Institutions

Institution	India's Role	Reform Demands
UNSC	Demand for permanent membership, G4 grouping (India, Japan, Germany, Brazil)	Expansion in permanent + non-permanent, Africa representation, voting reform
WTO	Key voice for developing countries. Doha round stall, fisheries subsidies, e-commerce moratorium, public stockholding (India's food security concerns)	Dispute resolution reform, special & differential treatment, agriculture negotiations
IMF	16th Review: quota increase but India's share still low (3.76%) relative to GDP	Quota formula revision (GDP weightage increase), governance reform
BRICS	Founding member, New Development Bank, Contingent Reserve Arrangement, expansion	De-dollarization, alternative payment systems, institutionalization

(2023: Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, UAE,
Saudi Arabia)

G20	India's presidency (2023): successful — African Union permanent member, digital infrastructure as theme, voice of Global South	Implementation of commitments, financing for SDGs, climate finance
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6. Answer Writing Strategy for GS2

6.1 The GS2 Answer Format

Structure for a 10-mark question (approx. 120-150 words):

1. Introduction: Define/categorize/contextualize (2-3 lines)
2. Body: 3-4 dimensions (analytical content with examples) — use sub-headings if needed
3. Conclusion: Balanced verdict + way forward (2-3 lines)
4. Value addition: Data point, committee recommendation, or comparative table embedded in body

6.2 GS2-Specific Writing Techniques

- **Constitutional questions:** Always cite Articles, Amendments, and landmark judgments. E.g., "While Article 14 guarantees equality, the Supreme Court in *Indra Sawhney v. Union of India* (1992) upheld the concept of reasonable classification..."
- **Governance questions:** Link to reports (NITI Aayog, CAG, Parliamentary Committees), current initiatives, and implementation gaps. Use the "policy-intent vs ground-reality" framework.
- **Social Justice:** Data is mandatory — NFHS, NSSO, PLFS, ASER. Connect to constitutional provisions (DPSP, Fundamental Rights) and international commitments (SDGs).
- **IR questions:** Show India's perspective but also present the other side. Use frameworks: "Neighbourhood First," "Act East," "Vision SAGAR." Cite recent summits, visits, and agreements.

7. Important Topics & PYQ Trends (2020-2025)

Topic	Frequency	Trend
Parliamentary Committees & Oversight	5	Increasing — scrutiny deficit, reforms needed
Federalism — Centre-State Relations	6	Governor's role, fiscal federalism, GST compensation
Judiciary — Appointment, Pendency, Activism	5	Debate-based — collegium vs NJAC, mediation
Welfare Schemes — Assessment	6	Data-heavy questions — performance, targeting, gaps
E-Governance & DBT	4	Impact assessment, challenges, JAM trinity
India's Bilateral Relations (USA, China, Russia)	6	Strategic autonomy, trade, security dilemmas
Multilateral Organizations Reform	5	UNSC, WTO, IMF — India's role and reform agenda
Social Justice — SC/ST/OBC/Women	5	Creamy layer, triple talaq, women's reservation (Nari Shakti Vandan)
Health & Education	5	NEP 2020, Ayushman Bharat, mental health, pandemic preparedness
Accountability Mechanisms (RTI, Lokpal, CAG)	4	Effectiveness + reform suggestions

8. Recommended Resources

Subject	Primary Source	Supplementary
Polity	M. Laxmikanth (Indian Polity)	DD Basu (Introduction), NCERT Class 11 & 12, PRS Legislative
Governance	ARC Reports (2nd ARC key chapters)	Vision IAS governance material, Hindustan Times editorials
Social Justice	NCERT Sociology + Current Affairs	India Development Report (IGIDR), NITI Aayog SDG Index
International Relations	Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) website	Vision IAS IR material, The Hindu (World section), ORF analyses
Current Affairs	The Hindu + Indian Express	PIB, Press Briefings (MEA), Rajya Sabha TV debates

9. 90-Day Preparation Plan

Period	Focus	Approach
Days 1-20	Polity — complete reading (Laxmikanth) + Supreme Court cases	Chapter-wise notes + article mapping + landmark judgment summaries
Days 21-30	Governance (ARC reports, RTI, e-governance)	Theme-wise notes + link to current developments
Days 31-40	Social Justice (Education, Health, Vulnerable sections)	Data compilation from government reports + budget analysis
Days 41-55	IR: Neighborhood + Major Powers + Multilaterals	Country-wise notes + recent developments mapping
Days 56-65	IR: Global issues + India's role (Climate, Terrorism, Energy)	Thematic approach — one issue per day
Days 66-75	Revision Round 1 — All topics	Revise notes, practice 1 answer/day, identify gaps
Days 76-85	Revision Round 2 — PYQ focused	Solve PYQs in timed conditions, peer review
Days 86-90	Mock Tests + Weak area focus	2 full-length mock tests, comprehensive review

Final Advice: GS2 is the most "current affairs heavy" paper. Your preparation must integrate static knowledge with contemporary developments. When you read about a new scheme, link it to constitutional provisions. When you read about a foreign visit, connect it to India's core foreign policy principles. This integration is what UPSC rewards.

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